

Reiterate The Purpose Of The Product At The Start Of Each Scrum Event

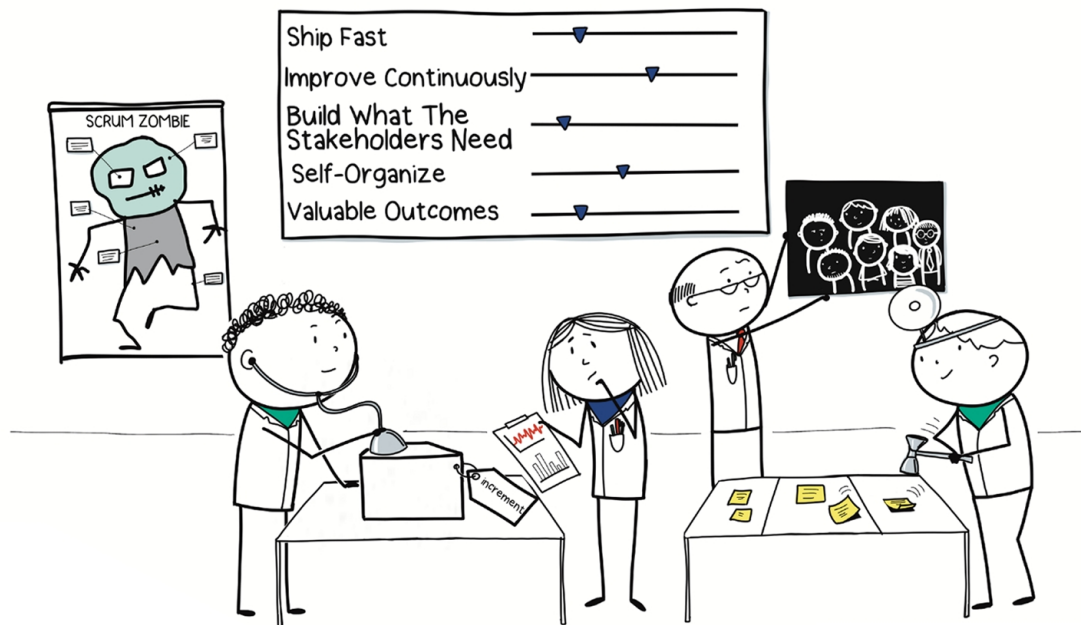
A simple experiment to increase the focus on what is valuable



Purpose Of This Experiment

Scrum makes so much more sense for Scrum Teams when they understand the purpose of their product. Unfortunately, Scrum Teams that operate in environments with Zombie Scrum often don't know why their product matters, what their stakeholders need nor what is valuable to them. They end up doing whatever ends up on their Product Backlog without having a sense of it all ties together. Or worse, they don't know the purpose of their product. Or there isn't even a product.

This experiment describes one tiny technique that can create big shifts in how teams experience the Scrum Events and the decisions they make during them.



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Provided you have a product purpose, this is an easy one to do.

Impact On Survival



A great start for important conversations.

Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Prepare visual aids to communicate the product purpose, like a product vision board or a purpose printed on a banner. You can easily bring these with you into the various Scrum Events. If you don't have a purpose statement at all, refer to "Our Findings" below for suggestions.
2. Begin each Scrum Event by reiterating the purpose of the product you're working on. It doesn't have to be literally the first thing you say, but make sure to mention it somewhere in the introduction. It's even better when you tie it to the purpose of the various Scrum Events.
3. For the Sprint Review: "We are developing this product to [purpose]. Let's use this Sprint Review to gather feedback on how the results from this Sprint have helped us make progress on that";
4. For the Sprint Planning: "We are developing this product to [purpose]. Let's use this Sprint Planning to decide what we're going to do this Sprint and how we will be working together to work towards that";
5. For the Sprint Retrospective: "We are developing this product to [purpose]. Let's use this Sprint Retrospective to figure out how we can collaborate more effectively to work towards that";
6. For the Daily Scrum: "We are developing this product to [purpose]. How can we collaborate most effectively in the next 24 hours to work towards that purpose?". You don't have to mention this every time;

Our Findings

- There is a risk of this becoming a mantra that is only mentioned, but not acted on in what happens next. Especially when the product's purpose is abstract and vague. A good way to prevent this is to find different ways or metaphors to express the purpose, let someone else do it each time, or re-invent the product purpose periodically. Keep it fresh.
- If you don't have a purpose statement for your product, this is an excellent opportunity to create the first version. The Liberating Structure "Nine Whys" can be a huge help here. Don't worry about finding the perfect sentence to complete "This product exists in order to"; it's better to have an incomplete, rough sense of why your product matters than no sense at all.

More Resources

- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk and Deliver Value Sooner](#) is a great way to get super clear on the purpose of the various events in general.
- Blogpost: [Make the Purpose of Your Work Together Clear with 'Nine Whys'](#)
- Canvas: [The Product Canvas](#) by Roman Pichler is a great way to visualize the purpose of your product.

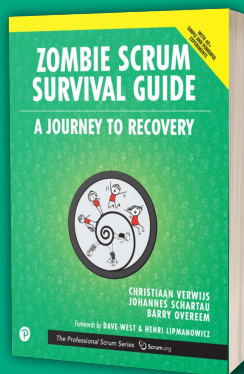
Help Us With Your Feedback



We are eager to learn how this experiment benefitted your team. What did it make possible? How did it help you make progress in your recovery from Zombie Scrum? With your data, we can improve our recommendations to other teams. You can share [your feedback](#) here with us in a only few minutes.



The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide



Zombie Scrum is on the rise! What may look like Scrum from a distance often turns out to be anything but when you take a closer look. Although teams go through the motions of Scrum, Sprints don't result in valuable outcomes, customers are not involved, teams have little autonomy and nobody is doing anything to improve.

A detailed examination of Zombie Scrum

In our book, we share our research and experience in the field with Zombie Scrum. We explore symptoms and causes, and dig deep into why Zombie Scrum usually starts when the purpose of Scrum isn't clear. With our book, the purpose of Scrum was never this clear!

Start your recovery tomorrow

The good news is that recovery is entirely possible. Our book contains over 40 practical experiments to start recovery, even when your organization has succumbed to it completely.

Get your copy now

You can find the 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' in your favorite bookstore starting from November 23, 2020. Or buy your copy from us at zombiescrum.org. The book comes with a free digital first aid kit, and a nice discount for a physical kit.



The Zombie Scrum Resistance

The 'Zombie Scrum Survival Guide' is written by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Schartau and Barry Overeem, and richly illustrated by Thea Schukken.

<https://zombiescrum.org>

info@zombiescrum.org